

The 15-Minute Vacation Planner

What you'll build: a day-by-day trip plan and a packing list for every person in the house — without 47 open browser tabs.

Planning a family trip usually means one mom, one laptop, and three hours of "wait, is that place even open on Mondays?" This lesson turns all of that into one conversation. You bring the destination. AI does the homework.

The steps

1 Tell it about YOUR trip (not a perfect trip)

Skip the travel-blog version of your family. Give Claude or ChatGPT the real one — ages, nap schedules, who gets carsick, the budget:

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We're going to [destination] for [number] days with kids ages [ages]. Plan each day with one main activity in the morning and something low-key in the afternoon. We need a break after lunch, nothing too expensive, and at least one rainy-day backup idea. Keep the driving short.

Read what comes back and push back like you would with a friend: *"Day 2 is too packed"* or *"my 4-year-old will not survive a museum."* It adjusts instantly.

2 Get a packing list for every person

This is the part moms usually do alone at 11pm the night before. Not anymore:

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Make me a packing list for this trip, with a separate list for each person: me, [partner], and kids ages [ages]. Include the stuff parents forget — chargers, medicine, snacks for the car, one extra outfit per kid. Format it as checklists I can print.

Kids old enough to pack themselves? Print their list and hand it over. That's their job now.

3 Make the "don't forget" list before you leave

The last 24 hours before a trip is when things fall through the cracks. Catch them all at once:

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We leave in [number] days. Give me a simple countdown checklist of things to handle before a family trip — like holding the mail, watering plants, emptying the fridge of things that will spoil, charging devices, and downloading movies for the car. Organize it by day.

Make it yours

- "Find free or cheap things to do near [destination] with young kids."
- "Plan the road trip itself — where should we stop for lunch and playgrounds on a 6-hour drive from [city] to [city]?"

- "We're flying with a toddler. Give me a survival plan for a 3-hour flight."

One quick check: AI is great at ideas and lists, but hours and prices change. Before you build a day around a specific place, take 30 seconds to check its website. Plan with AI, confirm the details yourself.

That's the whole lesson. You still get to be the fun one on vacation — you just don't have to be the travel agent too.